PHASE 2: INTEGRATION & VALUES

Welcome to Phase 2

You've completed Phase 1: Foundation & Stabilization. You've learned the fundamentals of managing urges, interrupting the cycle, challenging distorted thoughts, and practicing self-compassion. You've built a strong foundation.

Now it's time to build the life.

Phase 2 represents a shift—a shift from managing symptoms to creating transformation.

What's Different About Phase 2?

Phase 1 was about STOPPING the behavior:

- How do I recognize urges?
- How do I interrupt the cycle?
- What coping strategies work?
- How do I challenge distorted thoughts?

Phase 2 is about BUILDING the life:

- What do I actually want?
- What matters most to me?
- Who do I want to become?
- How do I create a life I don't need to escape from?

The Shift from Control to Acceptance

In Phase 1, you learned to manage and control urges using CBT techniques. That's important work, and those skills remain essential.

But here's the truth: **You can't control your way to freedom.**

No matter how many coping strategies you use, urges will still arise. Difficult emotions will still appear. Life will still be hard sometimes.

Phase 2 introduces a different approach:

Instead of constantly trying to control or eliminate uncomfortable thoughts and feelings, you'll learn to:

- Accept them as part of being human
- Observe them without being controlled by them
- Make choices based on your values, not your feelings
- Build a life rich with meaning and purpose

This is the foundation of **Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)**.

What You'll Learn in Phase 2

Weeks 9-10: Acceptance & Defusion

- How to work WITH difficult thoughts and feelings instead of against them
- Techniques to "unhook" from thoughts that drive compulsive behavior
- The difference between control and acceptance

Weeks 11-12: Values & Mindfulness

- What truly matters to you (not what you think should matter)
- How to define sexual integrity for yourself
- Mindfulness practices for staying present
- Accepting discomfort while moving toward what you value

Weeks 13-14: Committed Action & Identity

- Taking action based on values, not feelings
- Separating your identity from your behavior
- Who you are beyond CSBD
- Building a recovery lifestyle

Weeks 15-16: Integration & Prevention

- Comprehensive relapse prevention plan
- Integrating all the skills you've learned
- Creating a sustainable path forward

- Planning for the rest of your life

A Note on the Work Ahead

Phase 2 is deeper work. It will ask you to:

- Sit with uncomfortable emotions instead of escaping them
- Clarify what you truly value (which can be confronting)
- Face the gap between who you are and who you want to be
- Commit to actions even when you don't feel like it

This is not easy work. But it's transformative work.

If Phase 1 taught you to survive urges, Phase 2 will teach you to thrive in recovery.

Your Commitment to Phase 2

Before you begin, take a moment to recommit to this process.

I commit to Phase 2:

I acknowledge that:

- Building a life takes more than just stopping a behavior
- I will need to sit with discomfort at times
- Clarifying my values might reveal uncomfortable truths
- Transformation requires more than willpower—it requires vision

I commit to:

- Staying curious and open, even when it's hard
- Doing the values work honestly
- Practicing acceptance, not just control
- Building a life aligned with what truly matters to me

One thing I want to gain from Phase 2:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Let's begin.

WEEK 9: INTRODUCTION TO ACT & PSYCHOLOGICAL FLEXIBILITY

What Is ACT?

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT) is an evidence-based approach that helps you:

- Accept what's out of your control
- Commit to actions that align with your values
- Live a rich, full, and meaningful life

ACT is built on a simple but powerful idea:

Suffering comes not from having difficult thoughts and feelings, but from our struggle to avoid or control them.

The Problem: Experiential Avoidance

Most men with CSBD have spent years trying to avoid uncomfortable internal experiences:

- Avoid anxiety → Act out sexually for relief
- Avoid loneliness → Seek connection through fantasy or hookups
- Avoid shame → Isolate and numb out
- Avoid boredom → Seek intensity and stimulation

This is called experiential avoidance—using behavior to escape internal experiences.

The paradox: The more you try to avoid discomfort, the more it controls your life.

Example:

- You feel anxious → You tell yourself "I can't handle this" → You act out to relieve anxiety → Anxiety decreases temporarily → But now you've reinforced that you CAN'T handle anxiety → Next time anxiety appears, it feels even more unbearable

The cycle perpetuates itself.

The ACT Alternative: Psychological Flexibility

Instead of rigidly trying to control your internal experience, ACT teaches **psychological flexibility**—the ability to:

- Be present with what's happening
- Accept your thoughts and feelings without judgment
- Choose actions based on values, not feelings

Psychological flexibility means:

- "I'm feeling anxious AND I can still do what matters"
- "I'm having an urge AND I don't have to act on it"
- "This is uncomfortable AND I can handle discomfort"

The ACT Hexaflex: Six Core Processes

ACT is built on six interconnected processes:

```
    PRESENT MOMENT
        ↑
        |
ACCEPTANCE ← → COGNITIVE DEFUSION
        |
        ↓
    SELF-AS-CONTEXT
        ↑
        |
  VALUES ← → COMMITTED ACTION
```

1. PRESENT MOMENT AWARENESS Being here, now, instead of lost in past regret or future worry.

2. ACCEPTANCE Making room for uncomfortable thoughts and feelings instead of fighting them.

3. COGNITIVE DEFUSION Seeing thoughts as just thoughts, not commands or truths.

4. SELF-AS-CONTEXT Recognizing you are not your thoughts, feelings, or behaviors—you're the one observing them.

5. VALUES Clarifying what truly matters to you and what you want your life to be about.

6. COMMITTED ACTION Taking action guided by values, even when it's uncomfortable.

Over the next 8 weeks, you'll learn all six processes.

Psychological Inflexibility in CSBD

When you're psychologically inflexible, you get stuck:

EXPERIENTIAL AVOIDANCE

- Using sex to escape uncomfortable feelings
- "I can't handle this anxiety, I need relief"

COGNITIVE FUSION

- Getting hooked by thoughts
- "I'm having an urge" becomes "I MUST act on this urge"

DOMINANCE OF THE PAST/FUTURE

- Ruminating on past failures
- Worrying about future consequences
- Missing the present moment

ATTACHMENT TO CONCEPTUALIZED SELF

- "I AM an addict" (identity fusion)
- "I'm fundamentally broken"

LACK OF VALUES CLARITY

- Not knowing what you want
- Living on autopilot

INACTION OR IMPULSIVE ACTION

- Paralyzed by fear or overwhelm

- Acting impulsively to escape discomfort

CSBD thrives in psychological inflexibility.

Creative Hopelessness: What Hasn't Worked?

Before we move forward, let's look back honestly.

Creative hopelessness is an ACT exercise that asks: "What have you tried to control your urges, thoughts, and feelings—and has it worked long-term?"

The goal isn't to make you feel hopeless. The goal is to help you see that **the war you've been fighting is unwinnable**—and maybe it's time for a different approach.

EXERCISE 1: CREATIVE HOPELESSNESS

What have I tried to control or eliminate my urges and thoughts?

(Check all that apply)

- ☐ Willpower ("Just don't do it")
- ☐ Distraction (staying busy constantly)
- ☐ Thought suppression ("Don't think about it")
- ☐ Promises to myself or others
- ☐ Religious commitment or prayer
- ☐ Accountability software or monitoring
- ☐ Avoiding triggers entirely
- ☐ Cutting off technology
- ☐ Extreme self-discipline
- ☐ Self-punishment or shame
- ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

For each strategy, ask: "Did this work long-term?"

Strategy: _____

Short-term result: _____

Long-term result: _____

Strategy: _____

Short-term result: _____

Long-term result: _____

Strategy: _____

Short-term result: _____

Long-term result: _____

What has this struggle COST me?

Time: _____

Relationships: _____

Energy and mental space: _____

Opportunities missed: _____

Sense of self: _____

The workability question:

"Given everything I've tried, and everything it's cost me—is this approach working?"

If the answer is no, what might a different approach look like?

Introduction to Acceptance (Not Resignation)

Acceptance does NOT mean:

- Liking what's happening
- Wanting things to stay the same
- Giving up on change
- Tolerating harmful behavior
- Resigning yourself to suffering

Acceptance DOES mean:

- Acknowledging reality as it is
- Making room for uncomfortable experiences
- Stopping the fight with what you can't control
- Choosing how to respond instead of reacting automatically

Example:

Resignation: "I'm going to have urges forever, so I might as well give in."

Acceptance: "I'm going to have urges. That's part of being human. I can have urges AND still choose not to act on them."

Control vs. Acceptance: The Two Approaches

CONTROL APPROACH	ACCEPTANCE APPROACH
"I must eliminate urges"	"I can have urges and not act"
"I shouldn't feel anxious"	"Anxiety is uncomfortable AND I can handle it"
"These thoughts mean something is wrong with me"	"Thoughts are just thoughts"
Fighting with internal experience	Making room for internal experience
Rigid: "This feeling must go away NOW"	Flexible: "I can feel this and still move forward"
Life narrows (avoiding triggers)	Life expands (living by values)

The shift: From controlling your internal world to accepting it while controlling your actions.

EXERCISE 2: CONTROL VS. ACCEPTANCE IN MY LIFE

When I try to CONTROL my thoughts, feelings, or urges, what happens?

What do I do to try to control them?

_____

_____

Does it work? For how long?

_____

What does it cost me?

_____

_____

_____

What would ACCEPTANCE look like instead?

"I can have the thought/feeling/urge of _____

AND I can still _____"

_____

One situation this week where I can practice acceptance:

Situation: _____

What I'll be accepting: _____

What action I'll take based on values: _____

_____

_____

What Am I Avoiding?

Compulsive sexual behavior is almost always an avoidance strategy. You're using sex to avoid something else.

Common things men avoid through sexual behavior:

EMOTIONS:

- Anxiety, fear, overwhelm
- Anger, resentment, frustration
- Sadness, grief, loneliness
- Shame, inadequacy, worthlessness

- Even positive emotions (excitement, success)

SITUATIONS:

- Difficult conversations
- Conflict with partner
- Responsibilities or demands
- Uncertainty about the future
- Intimacy and vulnerability

TRUTHS:

- "My relationship isn't working"
- "I'm not living according to my values"
- "I don't know what I want"
- "I'm afraid of being truly known"
- "I'm not where I thought I'd be in life"

EXERCISE 3: WHAT AM I AVOIDING?

What emotion am I most often trying to avoid when I act out?

_____

What situation or responsibility am I avoiding?

_____

_____

What truth about my life am I avoiding?

_____

_____

_____

If I stopped using sexual behavior to avoid these things, what would I need to face?

_____

_____

_____

What would it mean to accept these things instead of avoiding them?

SKILL: LEAVES ON A STREAM

This is a simple mindfulness exercise to practice observing thoughts without getting hooked by them.

HOW TO PRACTICE:

1. **Sit comfortably and close your eyes** (or soften your gaze)
2. **Imagine a stream flowing in front of you**
   - See the water moving gently
   - Leaves floating on the surface
3. **Notice a thought**
   - Any thought that comes to mind
   - It could be an urge, a worry, a judgment, anything
4. **Place the thought on a leaf**
   - Imagine writing the thought on a leaf
   - Watch the leaf float down the stream
   - See it drift away
5. **Repeat with each thought**
   - As new thoughts arise, place them on leaves
   - Watch them float away
   - You don't have to do anything with them

The goal: Notice that thoughts come and go. You don't have to hold onto them. You don't have to push them away. You can just observe.

Practice this for 5 minutes daily this week.

LEAVES ON A STREAM PRACTICE LOG

Day	Practiced (Y/N)	What I Noticed	What Was Difficult?
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

At the end of the week:

How did it feel to just observe thoughts instead of engaging with them?

What did I notice about the nature of thoughts?

How might this practice help with urges?

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 9

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on control vs. acceptance.

Additional tracking:

- When did I try to control my internal experience this week?
- When did I practice acceptance?
- What am I avoiding?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 9 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 10, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 9 material and Phase 2 introduction
- [ ] Complete creative hopelessness exercise
- [ ] Reflect on control vs. acceptance in your life
- [ ] Identify what you're avoiding through sexual behavior
- [ ] Practice "Leaves on a Stream" daily for 7 days
- [ ] Complete practice log
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days
- [ ] Notice: When do I get stuck in control mode? When can I practice acceptance?

Notes for Week 9:

END OF WEEK 9